

TBW Assignment 1

Essay: Television's impact on the United States elections

Television has undoubtedly played a significant role in the United States presidential elections. Before TV, people relied solely on newspapers or radios for any political updates, but Television has made it easier for the public to access political figures which has been a major advantage, as Angus Campbell describes, marking "a new era ... in public communication" [1]. Television brings candidates directly into people's homes, making elections more accessible, easier to follow, and more interesting for the general public. This helps more people stay informed and take part in the process.

One of the greatest benefits of television is the increase in awareness of elections. People are better informed about the eligible candidates and their policies because of the TV coverage of debates, campaign rallies, and interviews. As Campbell points out, "the public has been given a new, immediate contact with political events" [2], making it easier for people to follow important moments in the political process without needing to attend events in person. This has made politics easier to understand, showing voters what's happening in real-time and helping them make more educated decisions.

Another key advantage is that television gets more people involved in voting. It brings debates, conventions, and speeches into people's living rooms, making them feel part of the process. This increased awareness encourages more people to participate in voting and engage in their

community as it promotes a sense of civic duty [3].

Watching candidates live on television, helps people connect with their leaders and feel more engaged, which often leads to more people voting and participating in democracy.

Moreover, television lets candidates reach thousands of people with their messages and not just rely on those who are there in person to convey their policies. If someone misses these broadcasts in real-time, they can catch up later when the programs are aired again or streamed on online platforms, making it easier for more people to stay informed. The streaming of their congressional hearings give the candidates a chance to explain their policies, answer questions, and debate their opponents. This helps voters understand where the candidates stand on important issues and see how they handle pressure.

Television also allows the common person to impact on national policy. As Ranney notes, when President Johnson heard Cronkite's report on the Vietnam War, he famously said, "It's all over." [4]. This shows how TV helps people to make sure their voices are heard, leading to policies that better meet their needs.

While critics say television focus too much on image, it helps candidates connect with voters. Seeing a candidate in action gives a better sense of their character, which is important for choosing a leader. As Mahand notes, "Kennedy's 'victory' in the debates was largely a triumph of image over content" [5], but that image helped him connect with many Americans.

In addition, Television also gives voters different

viewpoints and covers various political events, which helps democracy by encouraging open debate. As Hart and Triage suggest, TV makes people feel more familiar with candidates and their personalities [6]. This bridges the gap between voters and their leaders, making people feel more connected to the political process. Eventhough some entertainment aspects may seep into the coverage, TV still keeps people informed and engaged in politics.

In conclusion, while television has its limitations, its positive impact on presidential elections outweighs its drawbacks. It has made politics easier to access, increased voter ~~agreen~~ engagement, and allowed candidates to talk directly to the public. The influence of television has created a ^amore informed and involved electorate, making it a valuable part of the democratic process.

References

[1] Source A

[2] Source A

[3] Source A

[4] Source E

[5] Source C

[6] Source B

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